

Bengaluru Heritage

Architectural Guide

*A comprehensive guide to 13 iconic heritage sites
spanning over 1000 years of Bengaluru's history*

Covering: Chola Period (1085 CE) to Post-Independence (1956)

Architectural Styles: Dravidian, Indo-Islamic, Neo-Classical, Tudor Revival, Gothic Revival & more

Introduction

Bengaluru, the capital of Karnataka, is a city where history and modernity coexist in remarkable harmony. While globally known as India's Silicon Valley, the city harbors a rich architectural heritage that stretches back nearly a millennium. From the Chola-period Someshwara Temple in Halasuru (circa 1085 CE) to the monumental Vidhana Soudha completed in 1956, Bengaluru's built heritage tells the story of successive dynasties, colonial encounters, and post-independence nation-building.

The city was founded in 1537 by Kempe Gowda I, a chieftain under the Vijayanagara Empire, who built a mud fort and established the town's first markets. Under the rule of Hyder Ali and Tipu Sultan in the 18th century, Bengaluru was transformed into a fortified stronghold with grand palaces and botanical gardens. The British, after defeating Tipu Sultan in 1799, established a cantonment and introduced European architectural styles -- Neo-Classical civic buildings, Gothic Revival churches, and Indo-Saracenic institutional buildings that still define the city's central districts.

This guide covers 13 landmark sites across Bengaluru, organized by their historical era and architectural style. Each entry provides detailed information about the site's history, architectural features, and significance within the broader context of Bengaluru's urban evolution.

Architectural Styles of Bengaluru

Neo-Dravidian

A modern revival of traditional Dravidian temple architecture, characterized by massive granite construction, ornate pillars, and imposing facades that draw from South Indian temple traditions.

Exam

Tudor Revival

An architectural style inspired by medieval English Tudor architecture, featuring fortified towers, battlements, half-timbered facades, and ornamental woodwork reminiscent of English castles.

Exam

Indo-Islamic

A fusion of Indian and Islamic architectural elements, notable for pointed arches, ornate floral motifs, carved wooden pillars, and elaborate balconies reflecting Mughal and Deccan Sultanate influences.

Exam

Neo-Classical

A European-influenced style featuring symmetrical designs, Corinthian columns, pediments, and grand facades. Widely adopted during British colonial rule for public buildings in India.

Exam

Indo-Saracenic

A hybrid style blending Indian, Islamic, and Gothic Revival elements. Characterized by onion domes, pointed arches, minarets, and intricate jali screens, widely used in British India for institutional buildings.

Exam

Dravidian

The ancient South Indian temple architectural tradition, featuring towering gopurams (gateway towers), mandapams (pillared halls), monolithic sculptures, and intricate stone carvings depicting mythology.

Exam

Chola-Dravidian

A sub-style of Dravidian architecture from the Chola dynasty, known for its towering vimanas (temple towers), elaborate bas-reliefs, and bronze casting tradition that influenced temple architecture across South India.

Gothic Revival

A 19th-century architectural movement reviving medieval Gothic elements such as pointed arches, ribbed vaults, flying buttresses, and ornate spires, adopted in India for churches and public buildings during British rule.

Colonial Landscape

A landscape and garden design tradition blending Mughal garden symmetry with British botanical principles, featuring curated plant collections, ornamental glasshouses, and geometric pathways.

Historical Eras

Pre-Colonial (Before 1799)

The era before British dominion over Bengaluru, marked by the rule of Kempe Gowda, Hyder Ali, Tipu Sultan, and the Kingdom of Mysore. This period saw the founding of Bengaluru and the construction of its earliest forts, temples, and gardens.

[Sites](#)

British Raj (1799-1947)

The period of British colonial rule when Bengaluru became a major cantonment town, introducing European architectural styles alongside Indian traditions. Public buildings, churches, parks, and museums were built across the city.

[Sites](#)

Post-Independence (1947-present)

The modern era after India's independence, marked by monumental civic buildings expressing national pride and identity through revived Indian architectural forms.

[Sites](#)

Vijayanagara Empire (1336-1646)

The great South Indian empire that founded Bengaluru through Kempe Gowda I in 1537. The Vijayanagara rulers patronized Dravidian temple architecture, resulting in iconic temples with monolithic sculptures and elaborate carvings.

[Sites](#)

Chola Period (9th-13th Century)

The Chola dynasty controlled parts of the Bengaluru region and left behind some of the city's oldest surviving temples, characterized by refined stone carving and towering temple towers (vimanas).

[Sites](#)

Vidhana Soudha

Style:	Neo-Dravidian
Era:	Post-Independence
Year Built:	1956
Location:	Ambedkar Veedhi, Central Bengaluru
Architect:	Kengal Hanumanthaiah

The seat of Karnataka's state legislature, this massive granite structure is one of the most imposing buildings in India.

Vidhana Soudha is the seat of Karnataka's state legislature, located on Ambedkar Veedhi in the heart of Bengaluru. Constructed between 1952 and 1956 under the leadership of Chief Minister Kengal Hanumanthaiah, it stands as one of the most impressive examples of Neo-Dravidian architecture in modern India. The building was designed to symbolize the power of democracy and the sovereignty of the people of Karnataka.

Built entirely from Bengaluru granite, Vidhana Soudha is a four-storey structure featuring massive Dravidian pillars, ornamental domes, and a grand central stairway. The imposing facade stretches over 700 feet and incorporates traditional South Indian temple motifs into a modern legislative building. The inscription "Government's Work is God's Work" adorns the entrance in Kannada.

The building sits adjacent to the Attara Kacheri (High Court) and is a short walk from Cubbon Park and the State Central Library. Vidhana Soudha is beautifully illuminated on Sundays and public holidays, making it a landmark visible across the city skyline. It remains one of Bengaluru's most photographed monuments and a symbol of Karnataka's post-independence identity.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- State Central Library
- High Court

Bangalore Palace

Style:	Tudor Revival
Era:	British Raj
Year Built:	1878
Location:	Vasanth Nagar, Central Bengaluru
Architect:	John Cameron

Inspired by England's Windsor Castle, this palace features fortified towers, battlements, and Tudor-style wooden carvings.

Bangalore Palace is a stunning Tudor Revival-style palace located in Vasanth Nagar, in the heart of Bengaluru. Built in 1878 by King Chamaraja Wadiyar of the Mysore royal family, the palace was inspired by England's Windsor Castle after the young prince visited the English countryside. The architect John Cameron designed it with fortified towers, battlements, and Gothic-style windows that evoke medieval English grandeur.

The palace grounds span 454 acres and feature lush gardens, ornamental woodwork, and elegant interiors decorated with floral motifs, Victorian-era furnishings, and carved wooden ceilings. The Tudor-style half-timbered facade, combined with granite turrets and crenellated parapets, creates a striking silhouette that feels transported from the English countryside to tropical South India.

Inside, visitors can explore royal ballrooms, hunting trophies, and rare oil paintings from the Wadiyar dynasty. The grounds frequently host large-scale music concerts and cultural events. The palace stands as one of the few Tudor Revival structures in India and serves as a fascinating contrast to Bengaluru's predominantly Dravidian and colonial architecture. It remains privately owned by the Mysore royal family descendants but is open to public tours.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Vidhana Soudha

Tipu Sultan's Summer Palace

Style:	Indo-Islamic
Era:	Pre-Colonial
Year Built:	1791
Location:	Chamrajpet, Old Bengaluru
Architect:	Tipu Sultan

An elegant wooden summer palace known for its ornate pillars, arches, and fluted pillars in Indo-Islamic style.

Tipu Sultan's Summer Palace, also known as Daria Daulat Bagh, is an exquisite Indo-Islamic wooden palace located in the Chamrajpet neighborhood of Old Bengaluru. Completed in 1791 by Tipu Sultan, the ruler of the Kingdom of Mysore, it served as his summer retreat within the walls of the Bangalore Fort. The palace is one of the finest examples of Indo-Islamic architecture in South India.

The two-storey structure is built almost entirely of teak wood and features intricately carved pillars, cusped arches, and ornamental balconies. The interiors are adorned with vibrant frescoes depicting scenes from Tipu Sultan's battles against the British, floral arabesques, and geometric Islamic patterns. The fluted columns and elegant archways reflect the refined aesthetics of the Mysore Sultanate.

The palace stands near the remnants of the Bangalore Fort and offers visitors a glimpse into the life and reign of one of India's most storied rulers. After Tipu Sultan's defeat in 1799, the British used the palace as an administrative office. Today, it operates as a museum showcasing artifacts from the Mysore Sultanate, including Tipu's personal belongings, weaponry, and historical paintings. It is one of the oldest surviving structures in Bengaluru.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Bangalore Fort

State Central Library

Style:	Neo-Classical
Era:	British Raj
Year Built:	1915
Location:	Cubbon Park, Central Bengaluru
Architect:	British Colonial Administration

A red-painted Neo-Classical landmark inside Cubbon Park, housing one of India's oldest and largest public libraries.

The State Central Library, also known as Seshadri Iyer Memorial Hall, is a striking Neo-Classical building situated within the lush greenery of Cubbon Park in central Bengaluru. Established in 1915 and named after Sir K. Seshadri Iyer, the Diwan of Mysore, it is one of India's oldest and largest public libraries. The building was constructed under the direction of the British colonial administration as a public reading room and repository of knowledge.

The library's architecture features a distinctive red-painted facade with Corinthian columns, symmetrical arched windows, and a grand pediment entrance that exemplifies the Neo-Classical style popular in British India. The building's formal proportions and classical ornamentation reflect the European design sensibilities imposed on Indian civic architecture during the colonial period.

Located at the heart of Cubbon Park, the library is surrounded by botanical gardens, walking paths, and heritage trees that are over a century old. It sits in close proximity to other significant landmarks including the Vidhana Soudha, the Attara Kacheri (High Court), and the Government Museum. The library holds over 2.5 lakh books in multiple languages including Kannada, English, Hindi, and Sanskrit. It remains a beloved public institution and an architectural gem of Bengaluru's civic heritage.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Vidhana Soudha
- High Court
- Government Museum

IISc Main Building

Style:	Indo-Saracenic
Era:	British Raj
Year Built:	1911
Location:	Malleswaram, North Bengaluru
Architect:	British Colonial Engineers

The iconic main building of the Indian Institute of Science, blending Mughal domes with Gothic arches in a distinct Indo-Saracenic style.

The Indian Institute of Science (IISc) Main Building is an architectural masterpiece in the Indo-Saracenic style, located in the Malleswaram neighborhood of North Bengaluru. Founded in 1909 through the vision of Jamsetji Tata and inaugurated by the Maharaja of Mysore, IISc is India's premier research institution. The main building, completed in 1911, was designed by British colonial engineers who blended Mughal, Hindu, and Gothic Revival elements into a unified institutional facade.

The building features distinctive onion-shaped domes, pointed arches, intricate jali screens, and tall minarets that combine Islamic geometric patterns with Hindu decorative motifs. The red stone and cream plaster exterior creates a warm, inviting appearance, while the symmetrical layout and grand portico convey academic authority and permanence.

The IISc campus spans 400 acres of verdant landscape, home to rare trees, manicured lawns, and numerous research laboratories. The main building anchors the campus and serves as the administrative center and a symbol of India's scientific aspirations. The Indo-Saracenic style was deliberately chosen to bridge Eastern and Western traditions, reflecting the institution's mission of combining global knowledge with Indian scholarship. The building is a protected heritage structure and one of the finest examples of Indo-Saracenic architecture in South India.

Bull Temple (Nandi Temple)

Style:	Dravidian
Era:	Vijayanagara Empire
Year Built:	1537
Location:	Basavanagudi, South Bengaluru
Architect:	Kempe Gowda I

One of the largest Nandi (bull) monolithic statues in the world, this 16th-century Dravidian temple is dedicated to Nandi, the sacred bull of Lord Shiva.

The Bull Temple, also known as Dodda Basavana Gudi (Big Bull Temple), is a Hindu temple located in Basavanagudi, South Bengaluru. Built in 1537 by Kempe Gowda I, the founder of Bengaluru, the temple is dedicated to Nandi, the sacred bull and vehicle of Lord Shiva. It houses one of the largest monolithic Nandi statues in the world, carved from a single granite boulder measuring about 15 feet in height and 20 feet in length.

The temple is constructed in the Dravidian architectural style, featuring a towering gopuram (gateway tower), ornate stone pillars, and intricate carvings depicting scenes from Hindu mythology. The Nandi idol is coated with a mixture of groundnut oil and charcoal, giving it a distinctive dark sheen. According to local legend, the bull was once a living creature that terrorized farmers by eating their groundnut crops, and was turned to stone by a divine intervention.

The temple is the centerpiece of the annual Kadalekayi Parishe (Groundnut Fair), one of Bengaluru's oldest and most beloved cultural festivals, held in the Bull Temple grounds each November. The temple complex sits at the end of Bull Temple Road, near Bugle Rock Park and in close proximity to Lalbagh Botanical Garden, making it a key part of South Bengaluru's heritage corridor.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Lalbagh

Gavi Gangadhareshwara Temple

Style:	Dravidian
Era:	Vijayanagara Empire
Year Built:	1537
Location:	Gavipuram, South Bengaluru
Architect:	Kempe Gowda I

A unique cave temple known for its remarkable astronomical phenomenon where sunlight illuminates the inner Shiva Linga on Makar Sankranti each year.

The Gavi Gangadhareshwara Temple is a remarkable cave temple located in Gavipuram, South Bengaluru. Believed to have been built by Kempe Gowda I during the Vijayanagara Empire era around 1537, this temple is dedicated to Lord Shiva in his form as Gangadhara -- the bearer of the holy river Ganga. The temple is carved partially into a natural rock formation, giving it a distinctive cave-like atmosphere that sets it apart from conventional temples.

The temple is renowned for a stunning astronomical phenomenon: on the day of Makar Sankranti (mid-January) each year, the setting sun's rays pass precisely between the horns of a Nandi bull statue positioned outside, illuminating the Shiva Linga inside the inner sanctum. This alignment is evidence of the sophisticated astronomical knowledge of ancient Indian temple architects. The phenomenon draws thousands of devotees and scientists alike every year.

Within the temple complex, visitors can find two massive stone discs representing the sun and the moon, monolithic pillars, and carved panels depicting Shiva's various forms. The temple features classic Dravidian architecture with its mandapam (pillared hall) and a low-roofed garbhagriha (sanctum sanctorum) nestled within the rock cave. It is located near the Bull Temple in Basavanagudi and forms part of Bengaluru's ancient temple heritage trail.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Nandi Temple

Government Museum

Style:	Neo-Classical
Era:	British Raj
Year Built:	1886
Location:	Kasturba Road, Central Bengaluru
Architect:	British Colonial Administration

One of the oldest museums in India, housing rare collections of art, geology, numismatics, and archaeological artifacts from the Indus Valley Civilization.

The Government Museum of Bengaluru, also known as the Venkatappa Art Gallery and Museum complex, is located on Kasturba Road in central Bengaluru. Established in 1886, it is one of the oldest museums in India and the second oldest in South India after the Chennai Government Museum. The museum is housed in a grand Neo-Classical building featuring symmetrical facades, Corinthian columns, and a dignified entrance that reflects the British colonial architectural traditions of the late 19th century.

The museum's collection spans several departments: geology, art, numismatics, sculpture, and natural history. Notable exhibits include 12th-century Hoysala and Vijayanagara stone sculptures, rare coins from the Gangas, Chalukyas, and Kadambas, and archaeological artifacts dating back to the Indus Valley Civilization, including Mohenjo-daro relics. The Venkatappa Art Gallery wing showcases the works of K. Venkatappa, a celebrated court painter of the Mysore Kingdom.

Situated inside Cubbon Park and adjacent to the State Central Library and the Attara Kacheri (High Court), the Government Museum is a cornerstone of Bengaluru's cultural precinct. The museum offers a compact yet rich journey through Karnataka's history, from prehistoric times through medieval dynasties to the colonial era.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- State Central Library
- Mayo Hall

Mayo Hall

Style:	Neo-Classical
Era:	British Raj
Year Built:	1883
Location:	MG Road, Central Bengaluru
Architect:	British Colonial Administration

A stately Neo-Classical building named after Lord Mayo, the former Viceroy of India, now serving as a civic hall and administrative office.

Mayo Hall is a prominent Neo-Classical heritage building located on MG Road in central Bengaluru. Built in 1883, it was named in memory of Lord Mayo (Richard Southwell Bourke), the 4th Viceroy of India, who was assassinated in 1872 during a visit to the Andaman Islands. The hall was constructed during the height of the British Raj and served as a venue for public meetings, social gatherings, and administrative functions.

The building showcases typical Neo-Classical architectural features including a symmetrical facade, tall Corinthian columns, arched windows, and an elevated entrance with a grand portico. The structure is built from locally quarried stone and features a central hall with high ceilings. Its dignified yet restrained colonial aesthetic makes it a fine example of institutional architecture from the British period in Bengaluru.

Today, Mayo Hall continues to serve as a public building under the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP), the city's municipal corporation. It is located near St. Mark's Cathedral and the Government Museum, forming part of the MG Road heritage cluster in central Bengaluru. The building stands as a reminder of the city's colonial history alongside the more contemporary developments along the bustling MG Road corridor.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- St Marks Cathedral
- Government Museum

Bangalore Fort

Style:	Indo-Islamic
Era:	Pre-Colonial
Year Built:	1537
Location:	KR Market, Old Bengaluru
Architect:	Kempe Gowda I

Originally a mud fort built by Kempe Gowda I in 1537, it was later rebuilt in stone by Hyder Ali in 1761. The surviving Delhi Gate stands as a testament to Bengaluru's founding history.

Bangalore Fort is a historic fortification located near KR Market in Old Bengaluru. Originally built as a mud fort by Kempe Gowda I, the founder of Bengaluru, in 1537 during the Vijayanagara Empire period, it marks the very birthplace of the city. The fort was later strengthened and rebuilt in stone by Hyder Ali in 1761, and further expanded by his son Tipu Sultan, who added bastions, a moat, and additional defensive structures.

The fort originally had thick stone walls and multiple gates, but much of the structure was demolished by the British after their victory at the Siege of Seringapatam in 1799. Today, only the Delhi Gate (named because it faced the direction of Delhi) and a small section of the fort walls survive as protected monuments. The remaining gateway features Indo-Islamic arched doorways, bastions with loopholes for muskets, and inscriptions from both the Hyder Ali and British periods.

The fort is located in close proximity to Tipu Sultan's Summer Palace, which was built within the fort grounds. Together, they form the most significant pre-colonial heritage cluster in Bengaluru, telling the story of the city's transition from a Vijayanagara market town to a Mysorean stronghold to a British cantonment. The fort is maintained by the Archaeological Survey of India as a monument of national importance.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Tipu Sultan Palace

Someshwara Temple

Style:	Chola-Dravidian
Era:	Chola Period
Year Built:	1085
Location:	Halasuru (Ulsoor), East Bengaluru
Architect:	Chola Dynasty Artisans

The oldest temple in Bengaluru, dating back to the Chola period, this Dravidian masterpiece features intricate carvings and a towering gopuram dedicated to Lord Shiva.

The Someshwara Temple in Halasuru (Ulsoor) is widely regarded as the oldest surviving temple in Bengaluru, with origins dating back to the Chola dynasty around 1085 CE. Dedicated to Lord Shiva (as Someshwara, the Lord of the Moon), this temple is a fine example of Chola-Dravidian architecture and has been continuously renovated and expanded over nearly a millennium by successive dynasties including the Hoysalas, Vijayanagara rulers, and the Wodeyars of Mysore.

The temple complex features a towering gopuram (gateway tower) richly adorned with stucco figures of deities, a spacious pillared mandapam (hall) with intricately carved columns, and a central sanctum housing the Shiva Linga. The pillars display a mix of Chola-period simplicity and later Vijayanagara-era elaboration, reflecting the temple's layered history. Stone inscriptions found in the complex date to various periods and provide valuable historical records of Bengaluru's early settlement.

Located in Halasuru, one of Bengaluru's oldest neighborhoods, the Someshwara Temple remains an active place of worship and a cultural anchor for the local community. It hosts vibrant festivals including Maha Shivaratri and Karthikai Deepam. The temple's survival through nearly a thousand years of dynastic changes makes it the most historically significant religious structure in the city.

St. Mark's Cathedral

Style:	Gothic Revival
Era:	British Raj
Year Built:	1808
Location:	MG Road, Central Bengaluru
Architect:	Colonel J. J. Guthrie

One of the oldest Anglican churches in Asia, this Gothic Revival cathedral features elegant stained glass windows, a classic spire, and a serene cemetery within its grounds.

St. Mark's Cathedral is one of the oldest Anglican churches in Asia, located on MG Road in central Bengaluru. The cathedral was consecrated in 1808 during the early years of British rule in Bengaluru, making it over two centuries old. It was built under the supervision of Colonel J. J. Guthrie to serve the British military and civilian community stationed at the Bengaluru Cantonment.

The cathedral is built in the Gothic Revival architectural style, featuring a tall steeple, pointed arched windows, buttressed walls, and elegant stained glass panels depicting biblical scenes. The interior has a classic nave-and-aisle layout with wooden pews, a raised altar, and memorial plaques commemorating British soldiers and administrators who served in Bengaluru. The building's stonework and steeple create a striking silhouette against the modern skyline of MG Road.

The cathedral grounds include a peaceful cemetery with gravestones dating back to the early 19th century, offering a quiet respite from the bustle of one of Bengaluru's busiest commercial streets. St. Mark's Cathedral remains an active place of worship and hosts regular services, choral performances, and heritage walks. It is located near Mayo Hall and forms part of the MG Road heritage cluster alongside the Government Museum, Cubbon Park, and the Attara Kacheri.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Mayo Hall

Lalbagh Botanical Garden

Style:	Colonial Landscape
Era:	Pre-Colonial
Year Built:	1760
Location:	Lalbagh, South Bengaluru
Architect:	Hyder Ali

Commissioned by Hyder Ali in 1760 and later expanded by Tipu Sultan, this 240-acre botanical garden houses a Victorian-era Glass House, a 3000-million-year-old rocky outcrop, and over 1,800 species of plants.

Lalbagh Botanical Garden is a sprawling 240-acre garden located in South Bengaluru, widely regarded as one of the finest botanical gardens in India. It was originally commissioned by Hyder Ali, the ruler of Mysore, in 1760 and later expanded and enriched by his son Tipu Sultan, who imported exotic plants and trees from countries across the world including France, Persia, Afghanistan, and Turkey.

The garden's most iconic structure is the Glass House, a Victorian-era conservatory modeled after the Crystal Palace in London. It was built in 1889 and hosts the famous biannual Lalbagh Flower Show during Republic Day and Independence Day, attracting hundreds of thousands of visitors. The garden also features a 3,000-million-year-old rocky outcrop of Peninsular Gneiss, one of the oldest exposed rock formations on Earth, which serves as a geological landmark.

Lalbagh houses over 1,800 species of plants, including many rare tropical and sub-tropical specimens. The garden features ornamental flower beds, a lotus pond, an aquarium, a bonsai garden, and towering century-old trees. It was designated as a Government Botanical Garden in 1856 during British rule and has been managed scientifically ever since. Lalbagh is located near the Bull Temple in Basavanagudi and close to Tipu Sultan's Summer Palace, forming the green heart of Bengaluru's heritage landscape.

Nearby Heritage Sites:

- Nandi Temple
- Tipu Sultan Palace

Bengaluru's Heritage Landscape

Bengaluru's architectural heritage is a layered tapestry woven by Chola artisans, Vijayanagara founders, Mysorean rulers, British colonists, and post-independence visionaries. The 13 sites documented in this guide represent the full spectrum of the city's built history -- from the 1000-year-old Someshwara Temple to the mid-20th-century Vidhana Soudha.

What makes Bengaluru's heritage unique is its diversity. Within a few kilometers, one can walk from a Dravidian cave temple to a Tudor Revival palace, from an Indo-Islamic summer palace to a Gothic Revival cathedral. This coexistence of architectural traditions reflects the city's history as a crossroads of cultures, religions, and political powers.

The Bengaluru Heritage Explorer project aims to make this heritage accessible through modern technology -- combining AI-powered natural language understanding, knowledge graph traversal, multi-modal search, and audio narration to create an intelligent digital tour guide for one of India's most historically rich cities.